MARKET RESEARCH AND GO-TO-MARKET PLAN

IRAN IELTS MARKET, COMPETITORS AND THE PLAN TO ENTER IT

Who sells IELTS preparation to Iranians today, where the gaps are after the exam left the country in January 2026, how an AI-first tutor can be different, and a fourteen-month launch plan.

Research date: 26 October 2026 (4 Aban 1405). Prices are in toman as seen on the cited sites on that date. Toman loses value fast (open-market dollar ≈ 271,000 toman, up about 71% in a year), so treat every number as a snapshot. Items marked *unverified* could not be confirmed on a primary page.

> Scope note: this covers the whole Iranian market. A head-to-head section against one named competitor can be added on request.

1. THE MARKET IN ONE PAGE

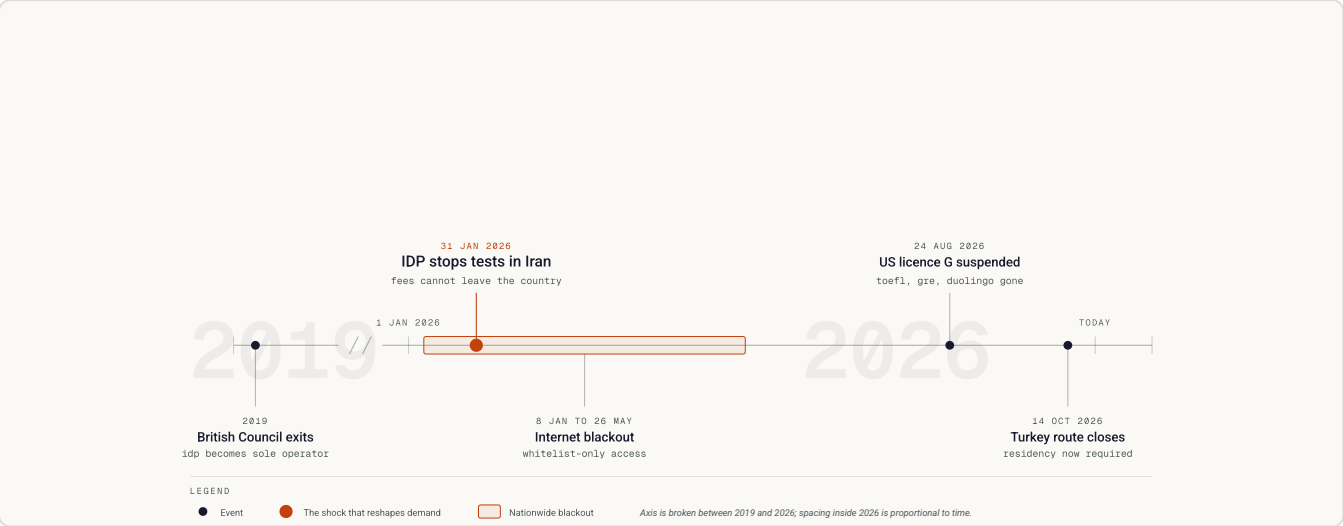


FIGURE 1 How IELTS left Iran, 2019 to 2026

The exam left the country. IDP, the sole IELTS operator in Iran since the British Council exit in 2019, stopped running tests inside Iran on 31 January 2026, citing financial and regulatory factors (sanctions blocking fee transfers). Afarinesh's price page, updated today, still says paper and computer IELTS are "currently not held in Iran". Candidates now sit the exam abroad through Telegram-organised "exam tours": Armenia (visa-free, ≈ $310), Georgia (≈ $293), UAE (≈ $433). Turkey closed to most Iranians on 14 October 2026 when British Council Turkey began requiring Turkish residency. A trip costs 300 million to 1.5 billion rials on top of the fee, and score-voiding and cancellation stories are common.

Alternatives are also gone. The US suspended OFAC General License G on 24 August 2026. ETS halted TOEFL and GRE in Iran. The Duolingo English Test is unavailable to anyone holding Iranian ID, even abroad. IELTS is now the only widely accepted English test an Iranian can reach, and it is a once-per-trip, high-stakes event.

Demand is real and migration-driven. Iranian students in the ten main destination countries roughly doubled from about 60,000 to 110,000 in four years. Canada and Germany lead, with Australia and the UK behind. Nursing and medical registration in the UK and Australia need IELTS 7.0 in every band.

Writing is the weak band. Iranian Academic averages (2024-25): Listening 6.47, Reading 6.72, Speaking 6.66, Writing 6.08. The gap between the Writing average and the 7.0 that registration bodies demand is the single clearest product opportunity.

Operating conditions are hostile. A nationwide internet blackout ran from 8 January to 26 May 2026. About 74% of users rely on VPNs; Instagram, Telegram and YouTube are filtered but still the main channels. Inflation is 60 to 90% a year. No Visa or Mastercard; payments run on domestic rails through gateways such as Zarinpal and Zibal, which require an Iranian entity with an e-Namad trust seal. Standard gateways do not do recurring billing, so the norm is prepaid packages. OpenAI, Anthropic and Google do not serve Iran-based companies; local startups buy LLM access through resellers (GapGPT, AvalAI) or self-host open models.

2. COMPETITOR LANDSCAPE

Incumbent institutes (where the money is today)

PLAYER	WHAT THEY SELL	PRICE SEEN (TOMAN)	MOCKS	CORRECTION	APP	AI	REACH
Afarinesh IELTS House afarinesh.org	Live online and in-person 50-hour cohorts (14 seats), mocks, free and paid correction	6.39 to 7.69 million per course; mocks 1.09 to 1.49 million	Yes	Human	No	No	Claims 990,000 learners since 2006, 109,000 in 1404; Instagram ≈ 208K *unverified*
IELTS Tehran ieltstehran.com	Levelled courses, workshops, offline videos, mocks, mentoring	6.9 million per level; offline workshops 2.2 to 2.9 million; online speaking mock ≈ 893K	Yes	Human	No	No	Telegram 22K, Instagram ≈ 98K *unverified*
Irsafam irsafam.org	Former largest test centre (5 cities), academy courses, computer mocks	≈ 2.59 million online course *unverified*; mocks 0.91 to 1.55 million	Yes	Human	No	No	Telegram 13K
Safir Goftman gosafir.com	Term-based live online classes on BigBlueButton, up to 24 terms	3.2 to 4.8 million per term	Separate	Human (SafirMall)	No	No	National chain
Iranmehr iranmehrcollege.com	Live classes, "no VPN needed"	Quote only	Yes	Human	No	No	Chain
Kanoon Zaban Iran (ILI) ili.ir	Intensive IELTS as a side product of general English	Not shown	No	No	No	No	State network
Bayan Bartar / IELTSFamily bayanebartar.org	Classes plus partner "IELTSmock" platform, 24-hour Task 2 correction, vague AI claim	Not public	Via partner	Human	Web app	Claimed	Telegram 21K
Zabanmehr zabanmehr.academy	Private and semi-private tracks, recorded skill videos	Quote only	No	Human	No	No	Tehran
IELTS2 (Pouya Abolghasemi)	Courses and correction bundles; website currently down	Not posted	No	Human	No	No	Telegram 9K

Content and marketplace platforms

PLAYER	WHAT THEY SELL	PRICE SEEN (TOMAN)	GAP FOR IELTS
Zabanshenas zabanshenas.com	General English app, IELTS packs inside Gold plan	≈ 40K per month yearly	No scoring, no mocks, no correction; 1.5M+ installs though
Maktabkhooneh maktabkhooneh.org	39 recorded IELTS courses, human correction packs	Courses 0.24 to 1.8 million discounted; 20 essays 4.5 million	No live practice, no AI, no simulator
Faradars faradars.org	Recorded Persian skill videos	≈ 110 to 115K per course	Shallow, no feedback
Lingano lingano.com	86-hour recorded mega-course, PWA app	9.9 million (list 28.5 million)	No personal correction in core course
Ostadbank ostadbank.com	Tutor marketplace	568K to 1.86 million per 90 minutes	About 10 IELTS tutors, no curriculum

AI-first local tools (small, but they exist)

PLAYER	WHAT THEY SELL	PRICE SEEN (TOMAN)	WEAKNESS
Testinno testinno.ir	IDP-style computer simulator, 60+ free tests, AI writing and speaking scoring, Leitner	459K per month; 1.95 million per year	1.3K installs on Cafe Bazaar, no human layer, no accuracy claims
AI Guru / aielts.ir	AI speaking (phoneme-level) and Task 2 scoring via "undisclosed foreign partner"	50K per essay	Pay-per-essay, no course, mocks "coming soon"
Fastdic AI fastdic.com/ai/ielts	AI writing scorer bundled with dictionary subscription	Subscription	Writing only
Armani English armanienglish.com	Human + AI hybrid correction, free computer mock	1.29 million for 4 essays	Fixed prompts, no speaking

The real free competitor is ChatGPT over a VPN. Persian blogs now teach "use ChatGPT as your examiner". Any paid product has to beat that on calibration, structure and Persian-specific guidance, not on raw access to a model.

The five gaps every incumbent shares

1. No AI feedback on writing or speaking at any institute. AI exists only at tiny tools.
2. No speaking simulator with instant scoring. Speaking practice is a human mock at 77K to 900K per attempt.
3. No mobile app from any IELTS specialist. The only apps with scale do not score IELTS.
4. Cohort scarcity and Tehran-centricity: fixed 50-hour cohorts that sell out in minutes, quote-only pricing, mocks in a handful of cities.
5. A high price per unit of feedback: 25K to 250K per corrected essay, 568K to 1.86 million per tutor hour, 6 to 8 million per course level.

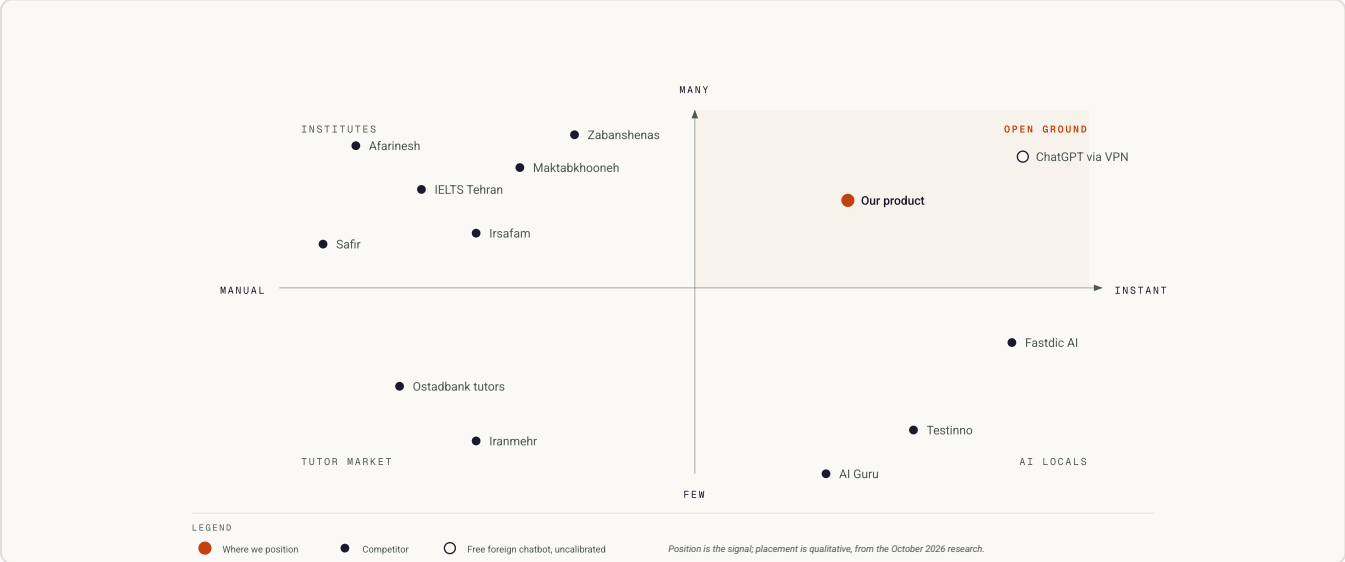


FIGURE 2 Competitors by feedback and reach

Who you collide with

- **Testinno**, feature for feature, but with almost no distribution.
- **Afarinesh**, for mindshare. It is the one most likely to bolt AI onto its free correction and mocks once a rival proves demand.
- **Zabanshenas**, for the mobile low-price end if it adds scoring.

3. HOW TO BE DIFFERENT

The positioning that no one in the table occupies: **"the tutor that gets you to 7 before your one expensive trip abroad"**. Everyone else sells classes or scoring. You sell readiness for a single high-stakes attempt, measured and in Persian.

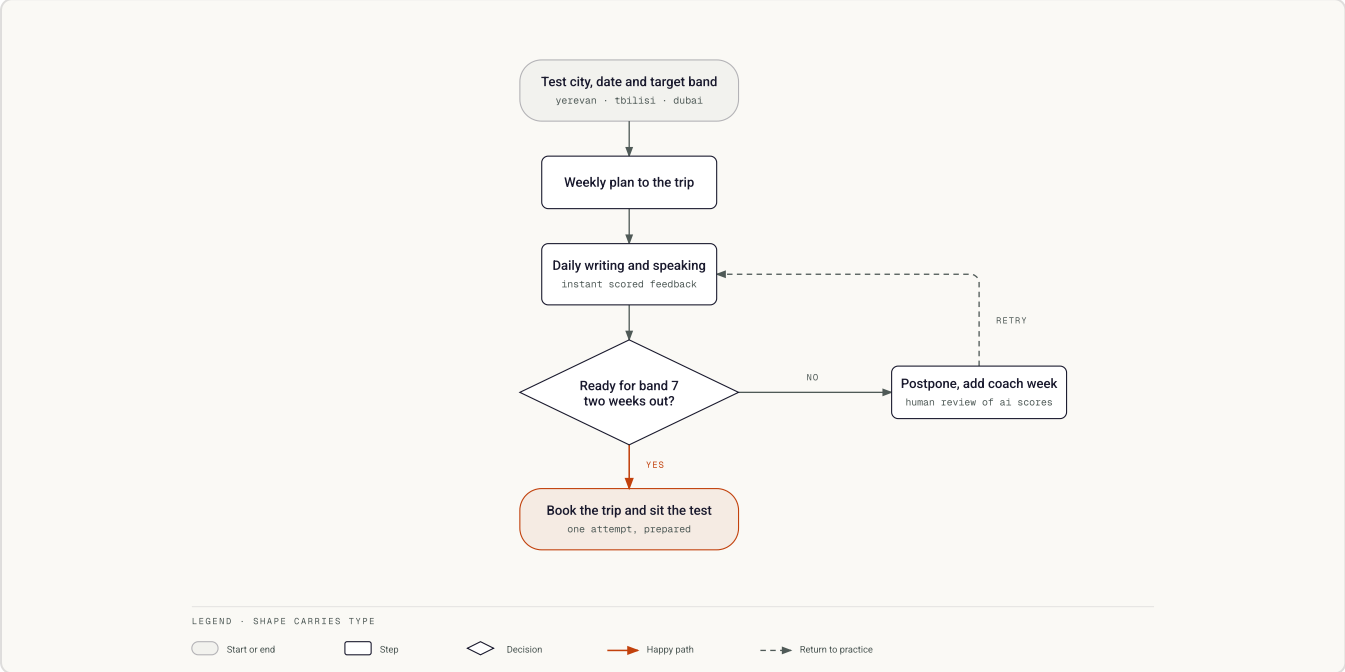


FIGURE 3 The trip-readiness loop

Seven differentiators, in priority order

1. **Trip-date readiness, not a course.** The learner enters the test date and city (Yerevan, Tbilisi, Dubai) and target bands. The product runs a countdown plan, a weekly readiness score per band, and a "go / postpone" verdict two weeks out. Include a logistics guide for each test city. Nobody else connects preparation to the trip, and the trip is now the biggest cost in the whole journey.
2. **Calibrated, explainable writing scores in Persian.** Score Task 1 and Task 2 against the four public criteria, show the band per criterion, and explain each deduction in Persian with the fix. Calibrate against at least 200 essays marked by certified examiners and publish the agreement figure (target: within half a band in 85% of essays). This is the direct answer to "ChatGPT does it free": ChatGPT does not tell you how far its score is from an examiner's.
3. **Persian-speaker error model.** Articles, prepositions, "the" overuse, tense sequencing, run-on sentences, and in speaking the /w/ and /v/ swap, /θ/, word stress and the flat intonation Iranians are marked down for. Build the feedback library around these patterns. This is what a British or Australian product can never do well and what the institutes do only through an individual teacher.
4. **Unlimited feedback for a flat fee.** The market prices feedback per essay or per mock. Unlimited AI writing and speaking attempts for one monthly or quarterly price changes the learner's behaviour (daily practice instead of weekly) and makes the incumbents' pricing look mean.
5. **Voice speaking simulator.** You already have the voice-tutor stack from Barex. A full three-part speaking test with an examiner persona, instant band estimate and pronunciation feedback is the second gap in the market and the hardest for institutes to copy.

6. **Human coach layer on top, like Barex Guided.** A small tier where a Band-8+ tutor (ideally ex-examiner) reviews the AI's assessment of two essays and one speaking recording a week, and runs one live call. It de-risks "AI only" for a 7 million toman buyer and gives you a defensible premium tier the AI-only tools cannot offer.
7. **Built for Iranian infrastructure.** Hosted or mirrored inside Iran so it works without a VPN, low-bandwidth mode, offline reading and listening sets, Android on Cafe Bazaar and Myket, a PWA for iOS, Telegram bot for submitting essays when the web is throttled. "Works during a shutdown" is a feature in this market.

What not to do

- Do not sell cohorts or fixed start dates. Start any day.
- Do not quote by phone. Public prices on the site.
- Do not claim a band guarantee; a Barex-style "retake support" promise is safer.
- Do not lead with general English content. Zabanshenas owns that.

4. GO-TO-MARKET PLAN

Beachhead

Iranian adults with Band 5.5 to 6.5 who need 7.0 (often 7.0 in every band) for Canada, Australia or UK study and registration, planning a test trip within six months. Writing first, speaking second. Secondary: the Iranian diaspora in Turkey, UAE, Canada, UK and Germany, who can pay in hard currency and already sit IELTS locally.

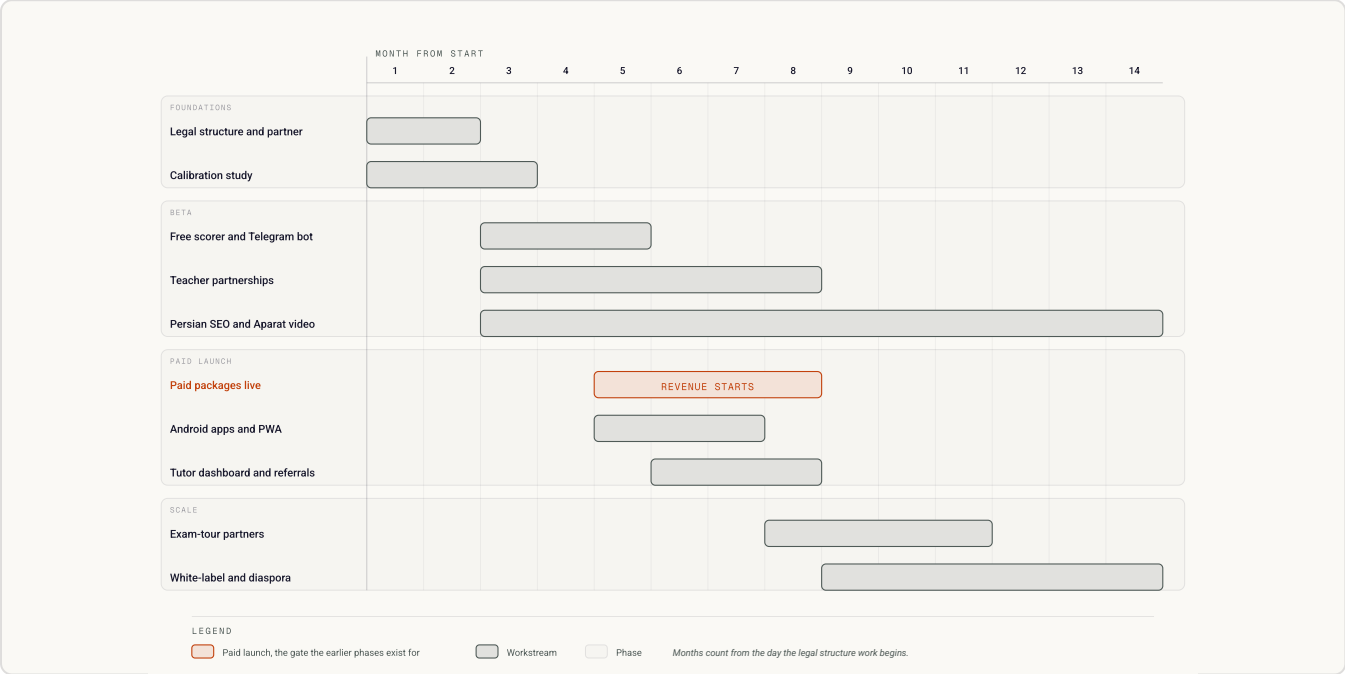


FIGURE 4 Launch plan, fourteen months

Phase 0: foundations (weeks 1 to 8)

- **Legal structure.** A UK operating company plus an Iranian partner entity that holds e-Namad, Samandehi registration and the payment gateway, under a licence and revenue-share agreement. Get UK sanctions advice before launch: UK rules are narrower than OFAC, but any US nexus (US cloud, US model providers, US investors) changes the answer.
- **LLM supply.** Decide between: (a) the UK company calling model APIs with the Iranian partner only reselling access (check each provider's terms), (b) an Iranian reseller such as GapGPT or AvalAI (terms risk), (c) self-hosted open models fine-tuned for scoring. Run the calibration study on two of these in parallel; the one that hits the half-band target at acceptable cost wins.
- **Calibration study.** Collect 200 to 300 essays and 50 speaking recordings marked by certified examiners (Iranian ex-examiners in the diaspora are reachable on LinkedIn). This is both your accuracy proof and your marketing headline.
- **Persian landing page and waitlist**, plus a free "score my essay" tool as the wedge. Capture target band, destination and planned test date; that data shapes the plan content.
- **Twenty interviews** with learners who travelled for IELTS in 2026 and ten with Instagram IELTS teachers. Validate the trip-readiness framing and the price bands below.

Phase 1: beta (months 3 to 5)

- Free unlimited essay scoring for the first 500 users in exchange for weekly feedback and their marked essays. Launch the Telegram bot version in the same week; Telegram reaches about half of users and survives throttling better than a web app.
- Recruit five Instagram IELTS teachers (10K to 200K followers) on a revenue share, each with a code. Teachers, not agencies, are the trusted voice in this market.
- Persian SEO on long-tail queries ("نمونه رایتینگ تسک ۲", "آیلتس در ارمنستان", "هزینه آیلتس ۱۴۰۵"). Google Ads accounts are not available to Iranians, but Google search is still where decisions start. Publish the test-city guides early; they rank and they pre-sell the trip-readiness idea.
- Aparat video series (legal, unfiltered) mirrored to YouTube for the VPN audience.

Phase 2: paid launch (months 5 to 8)

- **Packages, prepaid, repriced monthly.** Proposals to test, anchored on Testinno at 459K per month and Afarinesh at 7 million per course:
  - Self-study: about 790K to 990K toman per month, about 2.2 to 2.5 million per quarter, unlimited AI writing and speaking.
  - Guided: self-study plus weekly human review and one live call, about 4 to 5 million per month, positioned as cheaper than one Afarinesh cohort with far more feedback.
  - Diaspora: $19 to $29 per month self-study via Stripe on the UK company.
  - Treat these as hypotheses for the interviews and the beta, not as decided prices.
- Android on Cafe Bazaar and Myket, PWA for iOS, Sibapp listing if it is still operating at launch.
- Referral programme (you have one in Barex) with a free month for both sides. Word of mouth inside exam-tour Telegram groups is the cheapest channel in this market.
- Tutor dashboard: let independent IELTS tutors run their students through your scoring and plans, with a revenue share. It turns 568K-per-hour tutors into distribution rather than competitors.

Phase 3: scale and partners (months 8 to 14)

- Partner with exam-tour operators in Telegram and with the Yerevan and Tbilisi test centres' local partners: a readiness check and a discount for every tour booking.
- White-label the scoring to second-tier institutes in Isfahan, Mashhad, Shiraz and Tabriz that cannot build AI and resent Tehran's dominance. Avoid Afarinesh and IELTS Tehran; they are the ones who will copy you.
- Diaspora push in Turkey, UAE and Canada through Persian-language Instagram and Telegram, priced in hard currency.
- Yektanet and Tapsell native ads only once CAC is known from influencers; budgets in this market vanish for weeks during each crisis, so keep paid media variable.

Metrics to run the plan on

STAGE	METRIC	TARGET TO PROCEED
Calibration	Essays within half a band of examiner	85%
Waitlist	Sign-ups with a test date entered	2,000 before beta
Activation	First essay scored within 24 hours of sign-up	60%
Engagement	Essays or speaking attempts per active user per week	4+
Conversion	Free to paid within 30 days	8 to 12%
Retention	Paying users still active at month 3	50%
Unit economics	Influencer CAC vs quarterly package	CAC under one month's revenue

5. RISKS AND HOW THE PLAN HANDLES THEM

RISK	HANDLING
Model providers cut off access or terms forbid the use	Dual-source from day one; keep an open-model fallback; the UK entity, not the Iranian partner, holds API contracts
Sanctions exposure for a UK founder	Legal opinion before any toman revenue; keep US nexus out of the Iran-facing stack
Multi-month internet shutdown	Domestic hosting or mirror, Telegram bot, offline sets, SMS reminders; price in prepaid terms so revenue is banked
Inflation at 60 to 90%	Reprice monthly, sell quarterly packages, hard-currency diaspora revenue as a hedge
IELTS resumes in Iran	Good for demand; the trip-readiness framing becomes "test-day readiness" with no other change
Afarinesh adds AI	Your moat is calibration data, the Persian error model and the voice simulator, not "we have AI"
Platform accuracy doubted	Publish the calibration study; offer a human re-mark on request in the Guided tier

6. OPEN QUESTIONS

1. Which single competitor should get a head-to-head section?
2. Do you intend to operate from the UK company, a new Iranian entity, or a partner? The legal step gates everything else.
3. Will the Barex voice-tutor and mock-exam stack be reused? If yes, the speaking simulator moves from Phase 2 to the beta.
4. Do you want to serve the diaspora from day one, or Iran-only first?

SOURCES

Market conditions: iranintl.com (22 Sep 2026 exam tours; 29 Sep 2026 IDP exit), immigrationstartguide.com, afarinesh.org/ielts-price, ielts.idp.com/find-test-centres/iran, britishcouncil.org.tr IELTS dates, ofac.treasury.gov general licences, skadden.com Sep 2026 Iran measures, ieltsmentor.ai test-taker statistics 2024-25, iranintl.com Dec 2024 student numbers, rfberlin.com CREAM report Feb 2026, en.wikipedia.org 2026 Internet blackout in Iran, foreignpolicy.com Feb 2026 tiered internet, ispa-2026.netlify.app usage survey, digiato.global Yektanet 1404 report, zarinpal.com direct debit, peivast.com e-Namad rules, zoomit.ir e-Namad guide, proxy302.com supported countries, shabtabnews.com 21 Oct 2026, gapgpt.app, khabaronline.ir and fararu.com exchange rates 26 Oct 2026.

Competitors: ieltstehran.com product pages, my.afarinesh.org/online, afarinesh.org/ielts-mock-test, irsafam.org/mock/timetable, gosafir.com/mag/how-much-does-an-ielts-class-cost, iranmehrcollege.com, ili.ir, zabanmehr.academy, zabanshenas.com pricing plus Cafe Bazaar and Myket listings, maktabkhooneh.org/learn/ielts, faradars.org, lingano.com/courses/ielts, ostadbank.com/tutor-price/english/ielts, t.me/s/ielts2com, bayanebartar.org and t.me/s/IELTSfamily, testinno.ir/ielts-page plus Cafe Bazaar listing, aiguru.ir, fastdic.com/ai/ielts, armanienglish.com.